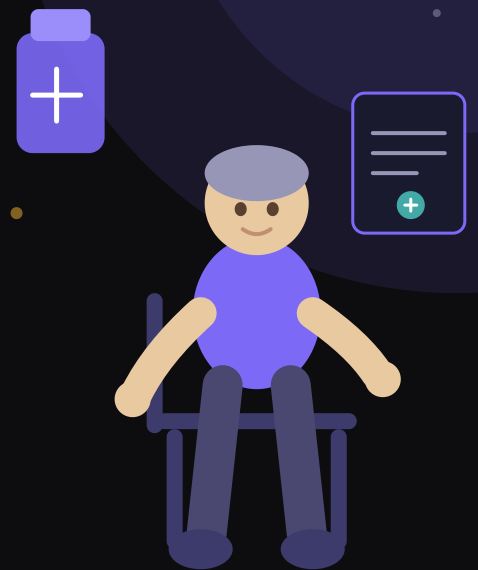


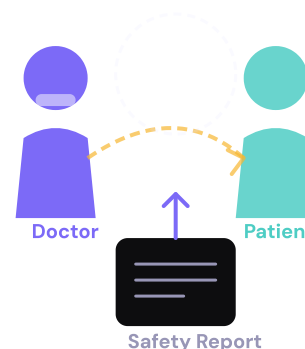
PLAIN-LANGUAGE GUIDE PHARMACOVIGILANCE

Pharmacovigilance Made Simple.

The story of Martin, a new medicine called Relvian and how the global drug safety system works — told in plain language.



What is pharmacovigilance?



When a medicine is approved and reaches patients, the clinical trials are over — but the learning has only just begun. Real patients are older, sicker, and taking other medicines. Some side effects are too rare to appear during trials. Others only emerge after years of use.

Pharmacovigilance — often shortened to PV — is the international system for monitoring, detecting, and responding to medicine safety issues once a drug is on the market. It involves doctors, pharmacists, patients, regulators, and manufacturers all playing a defined role.

"Pharmacovigilance is the reason a new side effect discovered in Denmark can protect a patient in Brazil."

130+

countries in the WHO safety monitoring programme

30M+

reports in VigiBase, the global safety database

Every

approved medicine is monitored for the rest of its life on the market

Meet Martin.

Martin is 61 years old. He lives alone, enjoys cooking, and until a few years ago walked his dog every morning without a second thought.

He has osteoarthritis in both knees. The pain crept up on him gradually — first a dull ache, then something that stopped him climbing stairs without wincing. Exercise helped a little. Over-the-counter pain relief helped a little. But neither was enough anymore.

His doctor decides it is time for something stronger.



HIS DIAGNOSIS

Osteoarthritis — a degenerative joint condition that causes pain, stiffness, and reduced mobility. It affects over 500 million people worldwide. It is manageable, but progressive. And for Martin, it is getting worse.

A new medicine.

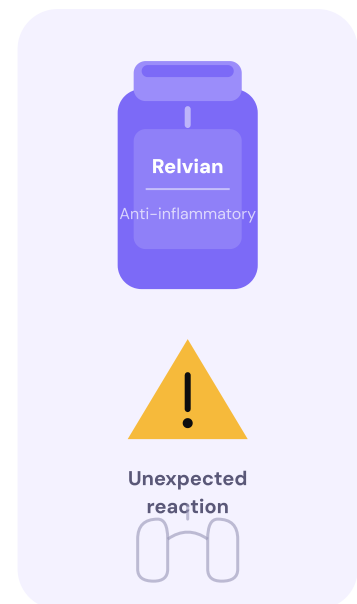
A new risk.

Martin's doctor prescribes him **Relvian** — a new anti-inflammatory medicine that has just been approved and entered the market. The clinical trials were promising. The benefit-risk balance was judged to be positive.

Martin collects the medicine from his local pharmacy. The pharmacist tells him about the known potential side effects: indigestion, dizziness, a mild headache. Nothing alarming. Martin begins taking Relvian as prescribed.

ONE WEEK LATER

Martin notices he becomes unusually short of breath when climbing the stairs. A dry cough appears that won't go away. He feels more tired than usual. He wonders if the new medicine could be responsible. He calls his doctor.



The diagnosis. The report.

CHAPTER 03 · THE DOCTOR INVESTIGATES

Martin's doctor orders chest imaging and blood tests. The results are clear: signs of **drug-induced pneumonitis** — inflammation of the lungs. He rules out infections, other medications, and pre-existing lung disease. The evidence points to Relvian.

Martin is advised to stop taking Relvian immediately. Over the next two weeks, his breathing improves, the cough disappears, and his oxygen levels return to normal. The link seems clear.

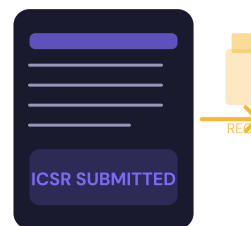
Drug-induced pneumonitis

Inflammation of the lung tissue caused by a medicine. Not listed as a known side effect of Relvian at this point.

CHAPTER 04 · THE SAFETY REPORT

Because the reaction was serious and not previously known, Martin's doctor is required to report it. He fills out an **Individual Case Safety Report (ICSR)** — a structured document describing the patient, the medicine, the timeline, the reaction, and the outcome.

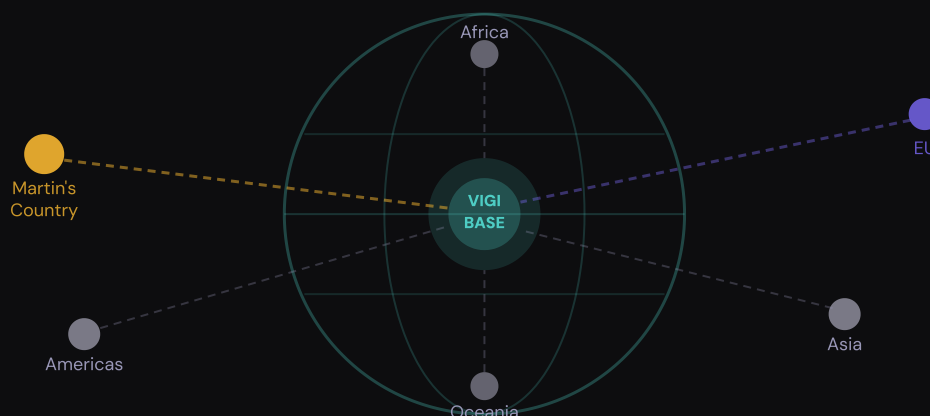
This report is sent to the **national regulatory authority**. It is the start of a process that reaches far beyond Martin's clinic.



One report. A global picture.

Martin's case is entered into the national adverse event database.

Because the country is a member of the **WHO Programme for International Drug Monitoring**, the report is automatically shared with **VigiBase** — the world's largest repository of medicine safety reports.



A case assessor at the regulatory authority reviews Martin's report alongside other similar cases in both the national database and VigiBase. A pattern emerges: a small but consistent cluster of lung inflammation cases linked to Relvian. Further analysis suggests the association is **probable**. This is called a **safety signal**.

WHAT IS A SAFETY SIGNAL?

A signal is information that suggests a possible new causal relationship between a medicine and an adverse event. It is not proof — it is a trigger for further investigation. Signals are generated by algorithms, expert review, or patterns spotted across databases.

A label is changed. A patient is protected.

Following signal evaluation, the regulatory authority concludes that Relvian is associated with drug-induced pneumonitis. It requires the manufacturer to update Relvian's product information immediately.

LABEL UPDATE

"Inflammation of the lungs" added to the list of adverse effects in the product information.

ADVISORY LETTER

A direct communication sent to healthcare professionals — GPs, specialists, pharmacists — alerting them to the new risk.

PUBLIC INFORMATION

Information published on the regulatory authority's website. Patients can access it.

MARTIN'S DOCTOR

Reviews prescribing guidance. His other patients on Relvian are now monitored for respiratory symptoms.



Glossary.

Every term from Martin's story, explained simply.

PHARMACOVIGILANCE (PV)

The science and activities relating to the detection, assessment, understanding and prevention of adverse effects of medicines.

ADVERSE EVENT

Any unwanted medical occurrence in a patient taking a medicine. Does not necessarily mean the medicine caused it.

ICSR

Individual Case Safety Report. A formal document submitted by a healthcare professional describing a suspected adverse reaction in a specific patient.

SIGNAL

Information suggesting a new or changed causal relationship between a medicine and an adverse event, warranting further investigation.

VIGIBASE

The WHO's global database of individual case safety reports. Contains over 30 million reports from more than 130 countries.

SIGNAL DETECTION

The process of analysing safety data to identify patterns that suggest a possible new or changed risk associated with a medicine.

LABEL UPDATE

A change to a medicine's official product information to add new safety information — such as a newly identified side effect or a new warning.

RISK MINIMISATION

Measures taken to reduce a known safety risk: advisory letters, restricted prescribing, patient monitoring requirements, or updated dosing guidance.



Martin's report made medicines safer for everyone.

He didn't do anything extraordinary. His doctor didn't do anything extraordinary. The pharmacovigilance system worked exactly as it was designed to. Every report matters. Every patient counts.

Qualivio supports pharmacovigilance professionals and organisations with education, consulting, and practical tools built around real regulatory frameworks.

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